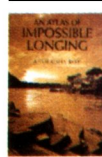


WINGS OF DESIRE

This first novel, an elegiac generational saga set in Bengal, captures the paradoxes of tradition and transition



AN ATLAS OF IMPOSSIBLE LONGING
by ANURADHA ROY
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■ By Brinda Bose

Now here is a perfect monsoon read: an exquisitely-written first novel that flows limpid and elegiac, even as the dark skies lower and the sodden trees sway. If you can watch the rain streaming past your window and let your imagination transform the sludgy waterlogged street below to a blue-grey rain-washed riverine panorama, you will best have soaked in its aura of impossible longing—for it is never a cascade or an efflux, and it never drowns you (or itself) in staggering sentimentality. In fact, it escapes, in Eliotesque vein, the very emotion that it seeks to capture—but then, as the poet astutely went on, only those who know such emotions know what it is to desire to elude them.

An Atlas of Impossible Longing—Anuradha Roy's first full-length work of fiction—is the story of three generations of a Bengali family living in small-town Songarh somewhere outside Bengal, of another house on the edge of a river in another small town called Manoharpur, and of two strays who wander into their family's life, the orphan boy Mukunda and the young widow Meera. Set in the first half of the last century, the novel is, almost inevitably of course, also a parable of "modern India", capturing the paradoxes of tradition and transition, snatching at those fleeting moments in which terrible beauties are born.

An Atlas charts its perilous course through the loves and longings of Amulya, scion of 3, Dulganj Road in

Songarh, his wife Kananbala (who is increasingly afflicted by a mysterious mad-curse disease), and their two sons Kamal and Nirmal, before coming to rest at Bakul, whose birth during a calamitous flood gained Nirmal a daughter at the cost of his wife's life. When Mukunda, the six-year-old illegitimate child of a tribal woman is given a home by the family, Bakul grows up in a curious intimacy with an older brother who is not her brother at all. When Meera, a childless widow and distant relative, is imported to look after the motherless Bakul's needs, her father finds himself both fascinated by, and fearful of, his desire to reach out to this outsider. Almost all loves and longings in *An Atlas* are melancholic, and subtly imperiled.

The novel begins with a prologue in the first person (whom we can never surely identify), which talks of a photograph of a house "afloat on a river the innocuous colour of darkening sepia". (One is reminded of the opening of Rushdie's essay 'Imaginary Homelands', gazing at a crusty,

yellowed picture of an old family house and ruminating upon the exercise of revisiting memories stored in brick and mortar.) The house and river in *An Atlas*'s prologue are indeed pivotal to the turning of Roy's tale—it is the ancestral home of Bakul's dead mother Shanti in Manoharpur, the home that she loses as a baby and must fight to regain as an adult. It is only fitting perhaps that this cobwebbed and crumbling house also retrieves for her—passingly, poignantly, promisingly—her precious childhood companion Mukunda, now grown up and married, with a son.

But then longings, however impossible they may be, have a capricious way of sneaking around incognito and springing up again in the most audacious fashion. *An Atlas of Impossible Longing* attempts that near-impossible task—of seeking to put down in words human yearnings that forever remain tantalisingly out of linguistic reach. It is not a gut-wrenching roller-coaster of a novel, and in its very quietness appears to deny the depth of the longings it nurses but conceals. This makes it one of those rare narratives that actually enacts the premise it is built upon. If it leaves you unsatisfied in parts, it possibly means that Roy has been unable to convince you of how impossible it is to translate such longings into language, and one would have to account for it as at least a partial novelistic failure. If, however, you let it under your emotional skin and allow it to roil your dormant but fretful fancies, you might find yourself unbearably moved by her delicate probing of the fragility of love and longing—looking into the heart of light, its darkness. ■



SAURABH SINGH